MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 3 — Unit 2: The Guide and Shame

INDIAN WRITING IN ENGLISH • M21EG04DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

The Guide and Shame question moral judgement through unstable identities, social expectations, and narrative forms that resist a simple verdict.

Start with a picture

Someone becomes what other people want to see in him; elsewhere, a society makes one body carry feelings it refuses to acknowledge. Both stories ask how reputations and moral labels are produced.

1. R. K. Narayan: The Guide

Raju begins as a tourist guide in Malgudi. His relationship with Rosie, an aspiring dancer married to Marco, changes his life. He becomes an artistic manager and benefits from Rosie’s success. Ambition, control, and deception lead towards imprisonment.

After prison, villagers led by Velan regard him as a holy man. Raju partly inhabits the identity they give him. Drought and the expectation of fasting turn that role into a test with consequences beyond his own comfort.

Rosie’s agency

Rosie is not simply the woman who causes a man’s fall. Dance represents artistic aspiration and the difficulty of acting independently within marriage and other controlling relationships. Examine what Raju’s narrative reveals and what his self-interest can obscure.

Narrative and ending

Retrospection connects Raju’s earlier career with his later position. Shifts in narration make readers evaluate the distance between explanation and self-justification.

At the end, Raju senses rain. The novel does not give a neutral confirmation that a miracle has occurred. The ambiguity permits questions about transformation, sacrifice, belief, and bodily exhaustion.

2. Salman Rushdie: Shame

The novel works through a fictionalised Pakistan while repeatedly questioning its own relation to political history. Omar Khayyam Shakil grows up in isolation under three mothers and enters the world with an injunction against shame.

The political worlds of Iskander Harappa and Raza Hyder connect private lives with rivalry and authoritarian power. Sufiya Zinobia becomes a disturbing focus of the shame others refuse to bear. Gendered violence and the distribution of responsibility are central.

Magical realism and allegory

Extraordinary events are narrated alongside recognisable political and domestic situations. **Magical realism** names a relationship between narrative modes, not simply any story containing something unusual. **Allegory** lets characters or events suggest larger systems without reducing the novel to a perfectly coded history textbook.

The narrator matters

The narrator comments on location, invention, distance, and storytelling. Such interventions unsettle a claim to transparent truth. Ask how the story is being constructed and what an account can include or exclude.

3. Compare the novels

Narayan often works through restrained irony and an ordinary social world. Rushdie uses excess, self-conscious narration, and grotesque transformations. Both make moral labels insufficient on their own. Explain their different methods rather than merely noting that both feature flawed people.

Quick check

1. Is Rosie only a plot device for Raju? **No; her artistic and personal agency matters.**
2. Is the rain’s arrival objectively certified at the end? **No.**
3. Is Shame a literal transcript of Pakistan’s history? **No; its fictional construction is explicit.**

Further term: Commonwealth literature

This historical publishing and critical label groups writing connected with the former British Empire or Commonwealth. It can aid comparison but may preserve a Britain-centred map of diverse literatures. Postcolonial criticism often questions that centre and the category’s exclusions.

Build an exam answer

1. Explain moral labels as a problem, not an answer.
2. Analyse Raju’s roles and Rosie’s agency.
3. Discuss retrospection and the open ending.
4. Explain shame, gender, and narrative excess in Rushdie.
5. Compare how each novel directs reader judgement.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not confirm a miracle the text leaves open or identify each fictional political figure as an exact historical equivalent.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Compare how narrative method complicates moral identities in the two novels.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

The Guide makes identity dependent on a changing relation between performance, desire, and social belief. Raju's different roles seem to offer coherent labels—guide, manager, prisoner, holy man—but none alone explains his actions. Retrospection asks readers to consider the motives behind his account, while the villagers' expectations give his final role a force he cannot entirely control.

Rosie's presence makes this moral inquiry relational. Raju's help and ambition are connected with his interest in possessing a position within her success. A reading that accepts his explanations without question would miss the novel's irony. The open ending likewise requires judgement without complete external confirmation.

Shame uses a more overtly extravagant narrative to expose the uneven allocation of moral feeling. Political actors evade responsibility while shame becomes attached to vulnerable bodies, especially women. The narrator's interruptions and extraordinary events reveal that the story is not an innocent mirror of history.

The contrast shows why method is central to an exam comparison. Narayan's restraint and Rushdie's excess organise different kinds of uncertainty, yet both make identity and public judgement unstable. A strong answer explains those formal choices through particular roles, narrative moments, or images.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt's assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Discuss the portrayal of independent Indian women by R. K. Narayan.
2. Analyse the humour in R. K. Narayan's novels.
3. Comment on Malgudi as a setting in the novel.
4. Analyse the character of Sufiya in the novel.

5. Analyse the thirst for power in the novel.
6. Explain the use of Magic Realism in Shame.
7. What are the features of magic realism in Fiction?
8. Elaborate on Commonwealth Literature.